We Speak Your Names - A Celebration

By Pearl Cleage

NOTE: The names Kamala Harris and Simone Biles have been added to this cutting, following Cleage's instructions to "adapt it" – Performers should feel free to add the names of black women who have shaped their world.

INTRODUCTION

For centuries, African American women have been remaking the world, giving testament to the power of hope, courage, and resilience. But it took the inspiration of Oprah Winfrey to honor fully the many gifts of sisterhood. For three amazing days–from May 13 to 15, 2005–a distinguished group of women was invited to celebrate the enduring achievements of their mentors and role models– and in the process pay tribute to the long, glorious tradition of African American accomplishment. The brilliant centerpiece of the weekend was the reading aloud of Pearl Cleage's poem "We Speak Your Names." With heartfelt eloquence, Pearl Cleage celebrates the priceless example of black women's lives.

We Speak Your Names by Pearl Cleage

"My sisters, here, there, and everywhere, this poem is for you. Use it, adapt it, pass it on . . ."

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Because we are free women,
born of free women,
who are born of free women,
back as far as time begins,
we celebrate your freedom.

Because we are wise women,
born of wise women,
who are born of wise women,
we celebrate your wisdom.

Because we are strong women,
born of strong women,
who are born of strong women,
we celebrate your strength.

Because we are magical women,
born of magical women,
who are born of magical women,
we celebrate your magic

My sisters, we are gathered here to speak your names.
We are here because we are your daughters as surely as if you had conceived us, nurtured us, carried us in your wombs, and then sent us out into the world to make our mark.

and see what we see, ***and be what we be***, but ***better truer, deeper*** because of the shining example of your own incandescent lives.

We know that we are walking in footprints made deep by the confident strides
Of women who parted the air before them like the forces of nature that you are.

We are here to speak your names because you taught us that the search is always for the truth
And that when people show who us who they are, we should believe them.

We are here because you taught us that ***sisterspeak*** can continue to be our native tongue,
No matter how many languages we learn as we move about as citizens of the world
And of the ever-evolving universe.
We are here to speak your names because of the way you made for us.
Because of the prayers you prayed for us. We are the ones you conjured up, hoping we would have strength enough,
And discipline enough, and talent enough, and nerve enough.
To step into the light when it turned in our direction.

We are the ones you hoped would make you proud

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Because all of our hard work makes all of yours part of something ***better, truer, deeper***.
Something that lights the way ahead like a lamp unto our feet,
As steady as the unforgettable beat of our collective heart.

We speak your names.
We speak your names.

Dr. Maya Angelou
Roberta Flack
Aretha Franklin
Nikki Giovanni
Lena Horne
Coretta Scott King

We speak your names.
We speak your names.

You could not have known how closely we watched your every move.
How we hung on your every word.
How eagerly we ran to sit cross-legged in front of the television
Whenever you were on ***Ed Sullivan*** or ***Soul Train*** or ***60 Minutes***.

How patiently we saved our money to buy that record, or that theatre ticket,

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Or that museum membership, or that magazine subscription
That would allow us to see you doing what nobody else had ever done before,
In just that way, on every front, ***all at the same time***.

We were so proud of you, it made us walk taller, smile wider, dream bigger.

You could not have been in each of our little black girl bedrooms,
Watching us hold that make-pretend microphone as we lip-synched your latest hit when dinner was ready downstairs,
Or curled up under the covers with your new book when we had math homework to do,
Or prayed for your safety when our parents told us you were somewhere
Fighting for our freedom, and it was dangerous work.
It is always dangerous work, but the trade-off is unacceptable.
From you we learned that freedom is non-negotiable.

You could not have known that your collective example
of the limitless possibilities that were open to us is what allowed us to look our mothers in the eye and say:
Mama, I want to be a singer
Mama, I want to be an actress.

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Mama, I want to be a dancer, or a sculptor, or a lawyer, or a leader,
Or a world-changing force for good, loose in the world, ***and whirling***. . .

And even when she rolled her eyes and shook her head
And pronounced us more our father's child than we had ever been hers,
She knew ***you*** had planted those ideas in our heads, and he thanked you for letting us see
That we could be a part of something ***better, truer, deeper***.

We speak your names.
We speak your names.

We speak your names.
We speak your names.

Gladys Knight
Patti LaBelle
Dr. Toni Morrison
Rosa Parks
Diana Ross

We speak your names.
We speak your names.

You change the world around you with such fierce determination,

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Effortless style, and unshakeable grace that we never suspected how hard it was to be out there in the real world,
Where sisterhood sometimes seems and abstract idea and not the living, breathing thing we know and need and want it to be.

We have sometimes shivered at the edges of a very cold place,
Where people do not always see our beauty
Or understand the rhythm of our song.
At those moments, we whisper your names as a talisman and a touchstone,
So we will not forget who and what and why we are here.

And then, ***sometimes***, in recognition of our superior skill, or our undeniable talent,
Or our absolute refusal to bend in the face of injustice,
Sometimes, we win the prize. ***The big one.***
The one they will mention forever after when they call our names,
Or write our reviews or compose our obituaries.

Sometimes, at that crucial, ***first one ever*** moment, we are invited to come to center court at Wimbledon,
Or up to the Oscar podium, or the Oval Office, or the Nobel ceremony,

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Or the Broadway stage, and express our feelings and the feeling of every other African American woman watching
At a moment when all we really want to do is call your names.
All we really want to do is thank all of you for being with all of us,
Whenever and wherever we find ourselves, standing alone in the light.
At those moments, we remember those lessons you shared
By living your very public lives with such integrity and honor
That they became something ***better, truer, deeper***.

We speak your names.
We speak your names.

Tina Turner
Alice Walker
Dionne Warwick
Oprah Winfrey
[Kamala Harris]
[Simone Biles]

We speak your names.
We speak your names.

We celebrate your courage.
We celebrate your spirit.
We celebrate your genius.

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And we stand before you now, your living legacy, the flesh
and blood of our collective dreaming, and we realize
with a knowing deeper than the flow of human blood
in human veins
That we are part of something ***better, truer, deeper***.

We speak your names.
We speak your names.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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